dynasty, is missing too. The point which emerges from all these reminiscences is that there were genuine local traditions that kept the memory of Ashoka alive, and within these he and his son were seen as having been among Kashmir's early rulers.

The story of Ashoka's association with Kashmir does not end here. It continues into the sixteenth century because the *Rajatarangini* is mentioned in Abu'l Fazl's famous *Ain-i Akbari*. When the imperial standards were carried into Kashmir, Akbar was presented with a copy of this history of Kashmir. Abu'l Fazl says: 'a book called *Raj Tarangini* written in the Sanskrit tongue containing an account of the princes of Kashmir during a period of some four thousand years, was presented to His Majesty. It had been the custom in that country for its rulers to employ certain learned men in writing its annals. His Majesty who was desirous of extending the bounds of knowledge appointed capable interpreters in its translation which in a short time was happily accomplished.'[53] Among the kings narrated as having ruled Kashmir is Ashoka, who 'abolished the Brahmanical religion and established the Jaina faith'.[54] Probably 'Jaina' is a mistranslation of 'Jina'—the word in Kalhana's *Rajatarangini* now repeated in Abu'l Fazl's account. Two of Ashoka's descendants, Jalauka and Damodar (II), also figure here. So Ashoka would have been known in Akbar's court and possibly beyond, via texts that used the *Rajatarangini*.[55]

The several mnemonic ways in which Ashoka's religion and rule survived from his death in the third century BCE to Akbar's day about 1700 years later show that the existence of this ancient ruler was never entirely forgotten. What one may well ask at this point is whether these memories of Ashoka were based on what he had himself put in the public domain or were a kind of concoction. Throughout, my own analysis of the historical Ashoka and of how he fashioned his image has highlighted the centrality of his representation as a Buddhist. His image as royal convert via edicts, his stupas and pillars, his stern proscriptions against the schismatically inclined,